

■ **National Disaster Response Force (NDRF):** The force works towards specialist disaster response under the NDMA. One NDRF battalion reached flood-affected districts on August 18 and had begun relief operations, but given the scale of operations, its efforts were too little to be able to make a difference.

STATE

■ **State Disaster Management Authority (SDMA):** The state's disaster response is headed by Chief Minister Nitish Kumar who also holds the disaster management portfolio. Chief secretary heads the State Executive Committee (SEC). Kumar was informed of the disaster only on August 19. He undertook an aerial survey on August 20. Relief operation could start only on August 22 with just two helicopters airdropping food packets for over two million flood-affected people.

■ **District Disaster Management Authority (DDMA):** Headed by the district magistrate, it acts as a planning, coordinating and implementing body for NDMA and SDMA. Unprepared and unable to cope with the disaster.

■ **Local authorities:** Panchayati Raj institutions, municipalities, district and cantonment boards and town planning authorities for control and management of civic services at ground zero were found incapable of responding to the colossal crisis.

ARMED FORCES

The core of the Government's response capacity and the crucial immediate responders in all disasters. Yet, the first columns of army reached the villages only on August 27, nearly nine days after the Kosi had inundated the plains. Over 141 naval divers and boats arrived on the spot only on August 31.

failed in executing relief operations." Kumar brushed aside such criticism telling INDIA TODAY: "Everybody must forget politics and help the victims. What we need is action, action, action, not *bhashan* (lectures)."

Yet with monsoons likely to subside only by the end of September, the danger only grows. And since the Government admits the breach cannot be plugged before April, that would mean these hapless people will have to weather the winter in relief camps. Keeping this in mind the Government should plan to keep the uprooted people in semi-permanent camps for periods lasting about nine months. Only after that the reconstruction and resettlement would start. Not only this, all infrastructure—roads, irrigation, power lines, hospitals, schools—created after the construction of embankments in the

1950s have been washed away. All the houses in 866-odd villages in 335 panchayats have been destroyed. The overall loss is expected to be Rs 10,000 crore. Besides, land and homestead, land deeds kept in these houses have been destroyed and once water recedes and the area becomes worth living, it would be difficult to prove ownership. This would lead to violence and clashes as the area is also known for its might-is-right demeanour. There are sufficient reasons for the health authorities to be on alert over possible disease and other infections if and when the flood water recedes, and also before that, especially in relief camps, which don't have medical facilities. Bihar's misery is far from over and it could get even worse unless the nation does all that it can to end the suffering.

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